

Week 6 Study Guide

Inspection (Observation) — Vitality, Color, Appearance, Five Sense Organs, Hair, Skin, Nails, Secretions, Pediatric Diagnosis

Lecture 6 · Lixing Lao, Ph.D., L.Ac., MB

How to use this guide: Read once for the framework (Zang-Xiang, Five Wheels, Five Colors), then drill the tables. Every enumerable finding-to-pattern mapping is in a table — memorize rows, not paragraphs. Pair with the Cram Sheet the night before class.

Quiz Scope Note: Prof. Lao stated in lecture that Body Constitution types (Five-Element constitutional typing) will **NOT** be tested on this quiz. That material appears in this guide for context only and is marked accordingly — do not over-invest study time there.

Print Edition

1 • Framework: Zang-Xiang & the Four Diagnostic Methods

Inspection works because internal organ states manifest on the body surface (Zang-Xiang theory). Three classical citations anchor this idea — know the concept, not the exact wording.

Source	Core Idea
Huangdi Neijing (475–221 BCE)	Internal viscera must manifest themselves externally.
Zhu Danxi (1281–1358)	Observe external manifestations to know what is happening inside; internal organ disease shows on the body surface.
Zhang Jiebin (1562–1639)	Zang-fu organs sit interiorly but manifest exteriorly — hence the name <i>Zang Xiang</i> ("viscera-image").

Quick Recall: *Zang Xiang* = what's inside shows on the outside.

Method	What It Uses	Key Point
Inspection (Observation)	Eyes — vitality, color, appearance, secretions/excretions	Includes tongue diagnosis as a sub-category
Auscultation & Olfaction	Ears (listening) + nose (smelling)	Sound and odor of the patient
Inquiry	Verbal questioning	History and subjective symptoms
Palpation	Touch, incl. pulse diagnosis	Physical exam

Heads Up — The four methods are never used in isolation — over-relying on one and neglecting the other three is explicitly called out in the slides as a diagnostic pitfall.

2 • Observation of Vitality (Shen)

Shen is the outward sign of the relative strength of Qi and Blood of the zang-fu organs.

Presentation	Meaning
Eyes clear, sparkling; vigorous mental status	Healthy Shen present
Eyes dull, cloudy; lethargic mental status	Shen disturbed; essence of the five zang organs weakened

Quick Recall: *Clear + bright eyes* = Shen present. *Dull + cloudy* = Shen disturbed.

3 • Observation of Color — The Five Colors of the Face

Color and luster of the face (or any skin area). General rule: a lustrous, moist complexion = mild disease, good prognosis. A dark, haggard complexion = severe disease, poor prognosis.

Color	General Indication	Key Variants
Red	Heat (excess or deficient type)	Entire face red = excess-type yang heat (exogenous fever, or zang-fu yang hyperactivity). Malar (cheek) flush only = yin-deficiency heat, often w/ tidal fever & night sweats
Pale (White)	Cold, blood deficiency, yin excess, yang deficiency	Bright white + puffy/bloated = yang qi deficiency. Withered pale = blood deficiency
Yellow	Deficiency, damp syndromes	Whole-body yellow (incl. eyes/skin) = jaundice. Bright orange = yang jaundice (damp-heat). Smoky dark = yin jaundice (cold-damp or chronic blood stagnation). Pale yellow, no brightness = qi & blood deficiency
Blue (Green)	Cold, pain, blood stagnation, convulsion	Pale + blue tinge = excess yin/cold w/ severe epigastric/abdominal pain. Blue-purple face+lips w/ precordial pain = heart blood stagnation. Blue-purple w/ high fever + limb movement in children = infantile convulsion
Dark Grey (Black)	Kidney deficiency, blood stagnation	Pale-dark + lumbar soreness + cold feet = kidney yang insufficiency. Dark, no brightness, scaly skin = prolonged blood stagnation

Quick Recall: *Red=heat, Pale=cold/blood-def, Yellow=damp/deficiency, Blue-green=cold/pain/stasis, Black=kidney/stasis.*

Heads Up — Homework/likely quiz format: build a comparison table of the five colors with TCM term + case example — this is exactly the assignment given in lecture. Expect a similar matching or fill-in format on the quiz.

Secretions & Excretions — General Color Rule

Presentation	Meaning
Clear and white (nasal discharge, sputum, urine, vaginal discharge)	Deficiency and cold
Turbid and yellow	Excess and heat

4 • Observation of Appearance, Movement & Body Shape

Body Shape

Presentation	Pattern
Overweight + mental depression	Qi deficiency with excess phlegm–damp
Thin person, dry skin	Blood insufficiency
Great weight loss over a long illness	Exhaustion of essential Qi
Large, barrel chest / full epigastrium	Full (excess) condition of lung and stomach
Large, overweight thighs	Spleen not transforming/transporting
Thin body overall	Yin deficiency
Overweight body overall	Yang deficiency with phlegm

Movement & Posture

Presentation	Pattern
Active movement	Yang syndrome
Passive manner	Yin syndrome
Violent movement of the four limbs	Wind disease (e.g. tetanus, acute/chronic infantile convulsion)
Muscle weakness, motor impairment, muscular atrophy	Wei (癱) syndrome
Pain, soreness, heaviness, numbness in tendons/bones/muscles + joint swelling/restricted movement	Bi (痹) syndrome (painful obstruction)
Numbness + impaired movement on one side of the body	Hemiplegia / wind-stroke
Quick movement + feeling of heat	Excess Yang
Slow movement + feeling of cold	Deficiency Yin
Small, restless fidgeting (e.g., leg bouncing)	Empty (deficiency) heat
Tremors, convulsions	Wind (involuntary movement)
Paralysis	Internal wind
Stiffness / rigidity	Qi stagnation, blood stasis, and/or internal wind

Quick Recall: Active/fast/hot = Yang excess. Passive/slow/cold = Yin deficiency. Involuntary = wind.

5 • Five Sense Organs I: The Eyes & the Five Wheels

The Liver opens into the eye, but the essential Qi of ALL five zang and six fu organs pours upward into the eyes (*Ling Shu* 80) — so the eye as a whole reflects Liver, but sub-regions reflect other organs via the Five Wheels.

Wheel	Eye Structure	Organ	Mnemonic
Blood Wheel	Inner & outer canthus	Heart (canthus also relates to Small Intestine)	Blood → Heart
Qi Wheel	Sclera (whites of the eye)	Lung	White = Metal = Lung
Wind Wheel	Iris (colored part)	Liver	Wind = Liver's pathogenic factor
Water Wheel	Pupil	Kidney	Black = Water = Kidney
Flesh Wheel	Eyelids (upper = Spleen, lower = Stomach)	Spleen/Stomach	Flesh = Earth

Heads Up — Right Chi pulse position pairs with Pericardium/San Jiao, NOT Kidney directly — don't cross-confuse pulse-position organ pairing with this eye-wheel organ pairing; they are separate systems.

Liver & the Eye — Functions

Liver harmonizes and distinguishes color; Liver stores Blood, which nourishes the eyes to allow sight; Liver governs tears, which moisten the eyes (basal/reflex tears for lubrication & protection — NOT emotional tears).

Eye Color

Color	Indication
Bright yellow (tangerine-peel)	Damp-heat, heat predominant
Dull, dusky yellow	Damp-heat, damp predominant
Dull, dark yellow	Cold-damp
Deep yellow + bloodshot	Toxic heat in the blood level (reckless blood movement)
Dull, dark yellow-brown	Blood stasis (with dark rings under eyes, pain, purple tongue, wiry pulse)
Red (inner/outer canthus)	Heart fire (or Small Intestine, if outer canthus)
Red, entire eye + headache, easily angered	Rising Liver fire
Red sclera, sore throat, cough, breathlessness	Exterior wind-heat affecting the Lung
Sudden red + itching + aversion to cold	Exterior invasion of wind-heat
Blue-green	Liver wind (involuntary movement, tremor, dizziness, numbness, paralysis)
Bluish	Internal cold (cold limbs, cold abdominal pain, tight/slow pulse) or Kidney Yin deficiency
Dark sclera (crab-eye black)	Accumulated heat
Dark eye sockets, sunken	Liver & Kidney Yin deficiency
White rings around iris	Turbid phlegm
Cloudy white iris	Liver & Kidney Yin deficiency
Pale white vessels in canthus	Blood or Yang deficiency

Quick Recall: Yellow=damp, Red=heat/fire, Blue-green=wind/cold, Black/dark=extreme heat OR extreme cold, White=deficiency/phlegm.

Eye Shape & Movement

Presentation	Pattern
Bulging / protruding eyeballs + anger, red tongue, yellow greasy coat	Liver Yang rising with heat and damp
Protruding + neck swelling, dizziness, tinnitus, five-center heat, red tongue, scant coat	Liver Yin deficiency with relative Yang excess
Sunken eyes + slight cough, weak voice	Lung deficiency
Sunken eyes + poor appetite, distention, limb weakness	Spleen deficiency (not transforming/transporting)
Sunken, sudden onset, deep/scattered pulse	Yin/Yang collapse (severe)
Swollen, sudden onset, no color change (edema)	Fluid metabolism malfunction (Spleen deficiency w/ damp)
Bags under the eyes	Spleen & Kidney deficiency
Strabismus / eye deviates, sudden onset, no redness/swelling	Wind attacking the channels
Deviation + nausea, vomiting, greasy coat, slippery pulse	Wind-damp-phlegm obstruction
Both eyes deviate up/high fever/convulsion/coma	Extreme heat generating wind
Deviation after trauma	Blood stasis
Congenital deviation (uni- or bilateral)	Essence deficiency (Kidney)
Frequent involuntary spasms, dry itchy eyes, pale face/lips, thready pulse	Blood deficiency
Eyelids heavy/tired feeling	Spleen Qi deficiency
Occasional spasm + red/painful/itchy + fever/chills, floating pulse	Exterior invasion (wind-heat)

Droopy eyelids (ptosis)	Qi sinking, or wind attacking the channels; after trauma = local stagnation/weakness
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6 • Five Sense Organs II: The Nose

Two valid organ associations: five-phase correspondence = Lung opens to nose; facial maps (both the *Su Wen* center-of-face map AND the *Ling Shu* bridge-of-nose map) = Spleen. Default study approach: think Lung + Spleen first, then read the other signs.

Finding	Pattern
Green/blue tip of nose	Cold
Yellow tip, yellow sputum, yellow coat	Damp (and heat, if thirst/sweating/feeling hot also present)
White / pale tip	Blood deficiency
Red tip	Heat
Gray tip	Impaired water movement → edema/fluid accumulation
Greenish bridge of nose	Liver Qi stagnation
Grayish-dark / dark purple bridge	Blood stasis (stabbing, boring pain)
Red bridge	Liver fire (irritability, outbursts of anger, red/bloodshot eyes, dryness)
Clear watery discharge	Cold pattern (exterior wind-cold)
Thick yellow discharge	Heat pattern
Dry and black	Toxic heat
Flaring of the nostrils	Extreme heat
Epistaxis (nosebleed)	Excess heat attacking lung/stomach, pushing blood out of the vessels
Swollen nose	Excess condition
Sunken nose	Deficiency condition
Nasal polyps	Stagnated heat in the Yangming channel

Quick Recall: Normal nose = slightly moist and shiny. Too dry = heat. Too wet/oily = damp.

Edema Location — The Three Yin Organs

Edema starts in...	Organ Implicated
Upper body / head	Lung (governs water pathways)
Lower body / feet	Kidney (source of body fluids)
Four limbs / torso	Spleen (transforms/transport water)

Heads Up — San Jiao is also involved in fluid metabolism, but the three *yin organs* tested for edema location are Lung, Spleen, Kidney — know the origin-site logic, not just the organ name.

7 • Five Sense Organs III: The Ears

The Kidney opens to the ear (basis of auricular acupuncture as a body microsystem).

Finding	Pattern
Dry, withered auricle, burnt black, chronic/severe illness	Kidney essence consumed, cannot nourish upward
Purulent ear discharge ("Tin Er")	Damp-heat of Liver & Gallbladder
Swelling/pain in middle ear	Heat in the Shaoyang
Thin ear	Qi or Blood deficiency
Long, full earlobes	Strong constitution / good Kidney essence
Small earlobes	Poor constitution

White, pale ears	Cold
Darkish / bluish ears	Pain caused by cold
Dry, withered earlobes	Kidney Qi exhaustion (usually Kidney Yin)
Shiny, moist earlobes	Good prognosis (Kidney Yin intact)
Dry, withered earlobes	Poor prognosis
Yellow/white pus discharge	Kidney Yin deficiency with fire, or Liver/Gallbladder damp-heat
Ear color: white	Sudden wind-cold invasion
Ear color: green/black	Pain
Ear color: black	Kidney failure
Ear color: red	Excess heat (possibly damp-heat)
Ear color: yellow	Damp accumulation

Tinnitus Pitch	Organ
High-pitched (like cicadas)	Liver
Low-pitched (like rushing water)	Kidney

Quick Recall: High-pitch tinnitus = Liver (cicada). Low-pitch = Kidney (water).

8 · Five Sense Organs IV: Teeth, Gums, Lips/Mouth, Throat

Teeth (Kidney — teeth are the "surplus of bone")

Finding	Pattern
White, moist sheen, bright/clean	Strong Kidney Qi
Dry, no sheen	Kidney Yin decline
Yellowing (gradual, with age)	Normal aging
Sudden dull yellow (like a soybean)	Kidney deficiency
Gray and black (like a black bean)	Exhaustion of Yin and Yang
Dry, black, gray	Kidney Yin deficiency
Tartar, grimy yellow	Stomach turbidity
Burnt and dry	Kidney & Stomach Yin deficiency
Delayed baby/adult teeth	Essence and Jing deficiency
Teeth growing at deviated angles / missing	Insufficient Yangming Qi (Stomach/Li wrap the mouth & gums, which are Flesh/Earth — not enough Earth Qi to hold teeth in place)
Loss of teeth in adult, receding gums	Fire flaring upward from Kidney Yin deficiency

Gums (Spleen/Stomach — Flesh)

Finding	Pattern
Moist, deep red (normal)	Normal
Deep red + swelling	Excess heat / Stomach fire
Pale	Blood deficiency
Atrophied	Kidney deficiency
Blue line between teeth and gums	Mercury poisoning
Swollen, ulcerated, bleeding	Stomach fire pushing blood out of vessels

Lips & Mouth (Spleen opens to the mouth)

Finding	Pattern
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Pale lips	Blood deficiency
Blue–purplish lips	Retention of cold OR blood stagnation
Bright red lips	Heat toxins
Crimson lips	Yin–deficiency heat
Dry, red lips	Heat damaging fluids
Purple lips	Blood stasis (stabbing pain)
Deviated mouth	Wind (deviation of face/mouth = wind; deviated tongue = wind too)
Mouth slightly open	Deficiency pattern
Mouth remains open + high fever, red face, thirst, canker sores	Excess heat
Breathing through open mouth	Empty/deficiency pattern
Open mouth + SOB + cough + frothy sputum	Lung deficiency with phlegm stagnation
Sudden attack, open mouth, drooling, loss of consciousness	Wind

Throat & Tonsils (Stomach + Lung primarily)

Finding	Pattern
Deep red throat/pharynx	Heat
Pale red throat	Empty (deficiency) heat
Acute pain + redness + swelling	Wind invasion (acute = exterior)
Chronic redness/swelling	Interior organ heat (Stomach heat)
Chronic sore, dry throat, NOT swollen/red	Lung and/or Kidney Yin deficiency with empty heat
Erosion, redness, swelling, yellowish–red	Heat in Stomach/Intestines
Chronic erosion, comes and goes	Empty (deficiency) heat
Chronic erosion w/ hard raised–edge ulcers	Blood stasis with phlegm–heat
Swollen tonsils, normal color	Damp/phlegm retention on background of Qi deficiency
Chronically red/swollen tonsils	Heat or toxic heat in Stomach/Large Intestine
Acutely red/swollen tonsils	Wind–heat invasion with heat toxicity
Acute red/swollen with exudate	Heat toxins in Stomach/LI (vs. cold)

9 • Hair, Nails & Skin

Hair (reflects Blood + Kidney Essence; "women ruled by Blood, men ruled by Qi")

Finding	Pattern
Original color, shiny, lustrous, moist	Sufficient Blood and Kidney essence
Premature graying	Depletion of Kidney essence
Dull, brittle, easily broken	Deficiency of Kidney essence (or Liver Blood deficiency)
Thick, lustrous	Sufficient Blood and Kidney essence
Thin, sparse	Deficiency of Kidney
Thinning / falling out (general)	Blood deficiency
Falling out in patches	Blood deficiency within the channels

Nails (reflect the Liver)

Finding	Pattern
Pink, normal luster	Sufficient Qi
Dark red	Heat

Pale	Blood deficiency or cold
Nail bed blanches white, returns to color immediately	Sufficient Qi and Blood
Nail bed returns to color slowly	Exhaustion of Qi and Blood
Withered, dried	Liver or Kidney Yin insufficiency; chronic Bi obstruction
Atrophied / peeled	Yin deficiency
Soft and thin	Deficiency of Blood
Rough, thick, dull, no transparency	Qi and Blood deficiency with wind
Longitudinal striping / blood loss appearance	Liver Blood deficiency, trauma, or fungal infection
Brittle	Blood deficiency, wind, or trauma
Hook-shaped	Qi and Blood stagnation, or wind-painful obstruction
Spoon-shaped	Qi and Blood stagnation, malnutrition, Spleen deficiency, chronic Bi
Ridged	Kidney Yin deficiency, Liver Yang rising, or Blood deficiency
Bluish veins on thenar eminence (palm)	Cold in the Stomach (thenar eminence reflects Stomach, via Lung channel)
Short bluish veins, thenar	Empty (deficiency) pattern
Red veins, thenar	Heat
Purple veins, thenar	Blood stasis

Skin

Finding	Pattern
Lustrous, harmonious color (normal)	Normal
Red	Heat
Yellow, orangish	Damp-heat, more heat than damp
Yellow, dusky	Damp-heat, more damp than heat
Too moist	Lung not controlling fluids
Dry	Blood deficiency / fluid deficiency
Dark, with scales	Blood stasis
Itching	Wind
Pitting edema (upper body downward)	Yang edema — Spleen/Kidney Yang deficiency, fluid not mobilized
Non-pitting edema	Qi stagnation or dampness
Edema starting from feet/lower body, worse below	Yin edema

Skin Lesions

Lesion	Description
Papule	Seed-sized rash, red, distinct raised borders, palpable; color fades with pressure
Macule	Flat red patch, clear edges, no swelling; color does NOT fade with pressure
Blister	Fluid-filled (clear or turbid), thick or thin walls
Nodule	Palpable, solid, round lesion

Term	Cause
Yong (癰) — carbuncle, Yang-type	Internal accumulation of fire toxins
Ju (瘰) — carbuncle, Yin-type	Insufficient Qi/Blood + internal stagnation of Qi, Yin, and cold
Ding (疔) — boil/furuncle	Exogenous wind-fire toxins, or accumulated heat toxins on the surface
Jie (癧) — furuncle	Stagnated Qi and Blood due to damp-heat in the skin

10 · Secretions & Excretions — General Logic

Quality	Reading
Color: white	Cold
Color: yellow	Heat
Consistency: thin, clear, watery	Deficiency / cold
Consistency: thick, sticky	Excess / heat
Quantity: profuse	Cold
Quantity: scanty	Deficiency / heat (heat dries fluids)
Odor: none/faint	Cold
Odor: strong	Heat
Form: with distinct form (e.g., hard dry stool)	Excess, tends toward heat
Form: formless / watery	Deficiency, tends toward cold

Quick Recall: White/thin/profuse/no-odor = cold-deficiency cluster. Yellow/thick/scanty/strong-odor = heat-excess cluster.

Heads Up — These four axes (color, consistency, quantity, odor) apply across nasal discharge, sputum, stool, and vaginal discharge alike — one framework, many tissues. Expect the quiz to test this transferable logic, not just one secretion type.

11 · Pediatric Diagnosis — Infant Finger Venous Diagnosis

Used for children under 3 years old (before the radial pulse is reliably palpable). Practitioner holds the child's hand with the left hand and rubs the index finger's radial-side vein toward the body (proximally) with the right thumb.

Side Examined	Sex
Left index finger	Boys
Right index finger	Girls

Gate the vein reaches	Severity
Wind Gate only (1st segment)	Mild illness / exterior pathogen
Qi Gate (2nd segment)	Interior condition, stronger illness
Life Gate (3rd segment)	Severe illness
Beyond Life Gate to fingertip	Life-threatening

Quick Recall: Wind → Qi → Life Gate = mild → stronger → severe → past the tip = life-threatening. Mnemonic: Wei-Qi-Ying-Xue four-level logic (Qi = interior stage).

Vein Color (after rubbing)	Indication
Light red, not very visible	Normal
Bright red	Heat
Purple	Stronger heat, creating stasis
Green or dark blue	Wind

Heads Up — This technique is infant-only (age <3) — it will not show reliably on adults. Don't confuse with the general adult nail-bed blanch test.

Quiz Scope Reminder

Heads Up — Prof. Lao stated directly in lecture: **"Nothing on the body constitutions"** will be tested. Five-Element constitutional typing (Wood/Fire/Earth/Metal/Water body types & personalities) is background context in the slide deck but is explicitly excluded from this quiz. Do not spend cram time memorizing constitution-personality pairings.